

The Nation Turns West — and the Cities Rise

The Rise of Industrialization · 1877–1900 | Standards US.01, US.02, US.03, US.04, US.05, US.06, US.07

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

As America industrialized, the same forces — the railroad, the factory, the open door — meant opportunity for some and loss for others. Whose America was being built, and at whose expense?

Hold this question the whole unit. You'll answer it at the end — in your own words, from the evidence.

1 Mission Vocabulary

Write what each word means as you meet it in the stories (definitions shown).

homestead	A claim of public land (usually 160 acres) a settler could earn by living on and improving it, under the Homestead Act of 1862.	assimilation	A policy of forcing a people to abandon their own culture and adopt the dominant one.
Jim Crow	State and local laws that enforced racial segregation and stripped Black Americans of rights after Reconstruction.	political machine	An organization (like Tammany Hall) that controlled a city's politics by trading jobs and favors for votes.
Gospel of Wealth	Andrew Carnegie's idea that the rich had a duty to use their fortunes for the public good.	nativism	Hostility toward immigrants and a preference for native-born residents.

2 Flight Log — every stop

One entry per landing. Jot what you *notice*, then answer the crew's debrief — the point isn't a right answer, it's your read of the evidence.

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Key (one defensible read)
1	Analyze how the Homestead Act and the transcontinental railroad drove westward settlement, and why the same expansion was opportunity for settlers... Notice: Here's the deal: move onto 160 acres, live there five years, plant something — and the land is yours. Free. Forever. No catch. Except the "empty"... Debrief: Anna and Chaska describe the same acres in opposite terms. Using one detail from each column, explain how the Homestead Act could be a genuine promise and a genuine injustice at the same time.	The Act gave landless immigrants like Anna's family a real chance at ownership impossible in Europe, and the railroad made it reachable. But that 'public' land was taken from Native nations like Chaska's. Strong answers hold both truths without treating them as equal in kind — opportunity for some was built on dispossession of others.
2	Analyze how the reservation system, the Dawes Act, and boarding schools sought to dissolve Native landholding and identity through forced... Notice: New rules at your new school: they hold you down and cut your hair, hand you a brand-new name, and punish you every single time you speak the... Debrief: Reformers called the boarding schools and the Dawes Act a benefit to Native people. Give the intended goal and the actual effect of this assimilation policy.	Intended goal: turn Native people into individual landowning, English-speaking 'citizens' by replacing communal land and culture. Actual effect: it broke up tribal landholding, opened vast 'surplus' land to non-Native buyers, and inflicted deep cultural and personal harm on children and communities.
3	Explain how the Compromise of 1877 ended Reconstruction and enabled Jim Crow, and evaluate the Freedmen's Bureau's intended role through a period... Notice: Picture the refs strolling off the field at halftime — and the other team gets to write the rules for the next eighty years. That's about what... Debrief: The Compromise of 1877 is often described as the 'end of Reconstruction.' Explain what changed for Black Southerners like Isaiah when federal troops withdrew, using the cartoon and Isaiah's column as evidence.	Claim: the withdrawal of federal protection allowed white Southern governments to impose Jim Crow. Evidence: the cartoon shows the Bureau as the force holding back white violence; Isaiah describes segregation laws and the loss of the vote once troops left, prompting the Exoduster migration. Reasoning: rights without enforcement collapsed into legalized oppression.
4	Analyze Gilded Age politics and economics — the power of trusts and machines and the divide between capitalists and wage earners — using a period... Notice: There's always a group that you're not in — the one where the real decisions actually get made. In 1889 a cartoonist drew America's version of it... Debrief: In 'The Bosses of the Senate,' the trusts are drawn as giants and the senators as tiny figures, with the 'People's Entrance' bolted shut. What is the cartoonist arguing about Gilded Age government, and which groups are left powerless?	The cartoonist argues that industrial trusts, not voters, controlled the Senate — that monopoly wealth had captured the government. The bolted 'People's Entrance' shows ordinary citizens — farmers and wage earners — shut out of political power.
5	Describe how industrial leaders and innovations transformed American life, and weigh the Gospel of Wealth against the conditions of the workers... Notice: A billionaire posts about donating a hospital wing — while the people who actually built his fortune can't cover rent. Real generosity, or a... Debrief: Andrew Carnegie's 'Gospel of Wealth' and the 'Next!' cartoon describe the same industrialists very differently. Make a claim about how much the Gospel of Wealth justified Gilded Age inequality, cite both sources, and explain your reasoning.	Strong answers weigh the Gospel of Wealth's claim (the rich as public-minded stewards funding libraries and schools) against the monopoly power shown in 'Next!' (Standard Oil's grip on government and industry) and Rosa's point that the wealth came from underpaid labor. Reasoning should assess whether philanthropy offsets or merely softens the inequality the monopolies produced.
6	Analyze how industrialization and immigration drove the growth of major industrial cities and shaped urban labor and living conditions. Notice: Your town runs on people who can't afford to live in it — the drivers, the cooks, the crew cleaning the building at five in the morning. That's... Debrief: Using the Ellis Island photograph and the 1890 foreign-born map, explain the relationship between immigration and the growth of America's industrial cities.	Immigrants entering through places like Ellis Island supplied the labor that industrial cities needed, and they settled where the work was — so the foreign-born population clustered in the same industrial states and cities (per the 1890 map) where factories, ports, and rail hubs concentrated jobs. Immigration and urban-industrial growth fed each other.
7	Compare 'old' and 'new' immigrants and analyze nativist responses, using a period photograph of tenement conditions. Notice: Same person steps off the boat. One country calls them an 'expat.' Another calls them an 'immigrant.' Another calls them a 'problem.' Same human... Debrief: Return to the essential question: whose America was being built, and at whose expense? Make a claim, cite evidence from at least two different spreads (including at least one image), and explain how opportunity and loss could be two sides of the same industrial expansion.	Strong responses argue that industrial America was built as real opportunity for some (immigrant homesteaders like Anna, wage-earning newcomers like Rosa, Exodusters like Isaiah) at real expense to others (Native dispossession and assimilation for Chaska, Jim Crow for Black Southerners, exploited labor and nativism in the cities). Evidence should span spreads and cite images (e.g., the Golden Spike or Torino photos vs. the Bosses of the Senate or Riis photo). Reasoning should show the same forces — railroad, factory, open door — produced both, and that who benefited often depended on race, class, and origin.

S Source Detective

Find this primary source in Unit 1 of your book, then work it like an investigator: **Golden Spike Ceremony at Promontory Summit, Utah, May 10, 1869 — completion of the first transcontinental railroad.**

1. Who made this, and when? Whose point of view does it show — and whose is missing?
2. Spark's question: *Everyone in this famous photo is celebrating. Ask: who is not in the picture? Whose land and labor made this moment possible but were left out of...*
3. What does this source prove — and what does it *not* prove on its own?

Teacher note: Unit thesis: 'settlement' and 'dispossession' name the same event from two vantage points. Hold the hard line — empathy for settlers is not neutrality about the taking of Native land.

A The Arc of the Union — *your call*

For each milestone, decide: did it move the country **toward** its founding promise — liberty and equality *for all* — or **away**? There's no answer key. Mark your read and back it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	Historians' read (one reading, not the answer)
1869	Homestead Act & transcontinental railroad	Mixed Genuinely contested against the 'more perfect union' yardstick: historians widely credit these policies with democratizing landownership and...
1877	Compromise of 1877 ends Reconstruction	Setback Broad scholarly consensus (e.g., Eric Foner) holds that withdrawing federal enforcement enabled Black disenfranchisement and racial violence - a...
1881	Tennessee's separate-car law	Setback Codifying racial segregation in law is broadly accepted by historians as a retreat from equal protection under the law.
1887	Dawes Act	Setback Widely assessed by historians as destructive: allotment contributed to the loss of roughly two-thirds of tribal lands and eroded Native...
1890	Sherman Antitrust Act	Climb Broadly regarded as a foundational check on concentrated economic power and a step toward fairer markets, though scholars note early enforcement...
1892	Ida B. Wells's anti-lynching campaign	Climb Recognized as a landmark in the struggle for equal justice and a free press - a moral and civic advance - even though the federal legislative...
1896	Tennessee ends convict leasing	Climb Ending the lease of prisoners to private companies is accepted as a labor and human-rights advance; historians note the state then shifted to its...
1901	NY Tenement House Act	Climb A landmark Progressive housing-reform law broadly credited with improving urban living conditions and public health.
1911	Standard Oil broken up	Climb Widely treated as a milestone in curbing monopoly power and enforcing antitrust law, though economists still debate its long-run market effects.

B Debrief & Closing Argument

This unit is one chapter of a project older than any of us - the one the Constitution names in its first line: forming 'a more perfect union.'...

Closing question: Look for a pattern across these seven stories: a problem gets ignored until it hurts people badly enough that someone refuses to stay silent - and their voice (a photograph, a newspaper, a strike, a vote) pushes the government to act. Sometimes the fix came fast (the Sherman Antitrust Act; Tennessee ending convict leasing). Sometimes it took generations (a federal anti-lynching law). Sometimes the government itself caused the harm (federal Indian policy). Choose two moments from this unit and argue, with evidence: in these years, did the country climb toward a 'more perfect union,' or slip back? There is no answer key - defend yours.

Facilitation: There is no single correct verdict — students must choose moments and defend a direction with evidence. Reward a claim that holds competing truths (opportunity *and* injustice in the same years) over a tidy one-sided answer.

Back to the Essential Question — your answer now:

Answers vary; look for direct use of unit evidence and a defensible position, not a memorized "right" answer.